Middle Ground

One of three shortlisted new CEA links, in ten minutes

For managers · from 1 January 2027 · 26 weeks · code MG-26-T8 · the full proposal sheet has the detail

The short version

Four numbers

9 of 9

December staffing rules met

today 4 of 9

35h

contracted hours a week

Mon–Sat average

0

avoidable fatigue warnings

cover weeks aside

26

people on the link

today 20

Every December staffing rule met — and 30 days off for 14 days’ leave, as now.

The staffing you asked for

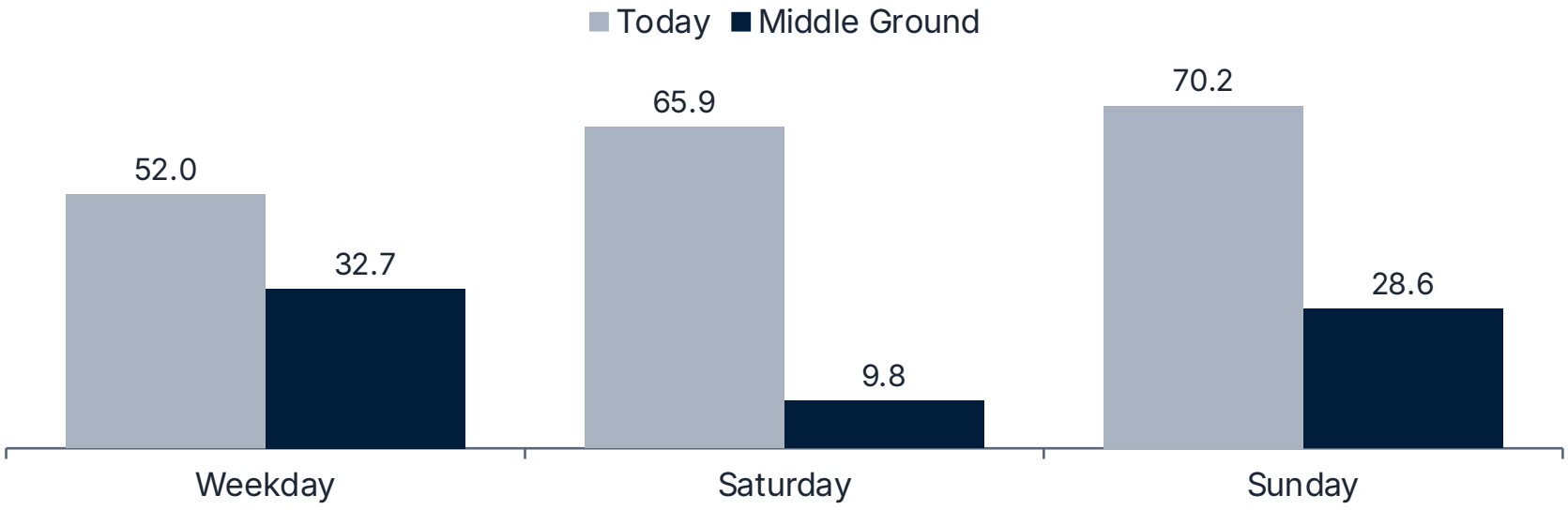
Each figure reads weekday · Saturday · Sunday

	Today	Middle Ground
On duty each day (Sunday: at least 10)	11–12 · 10 · 8	✓ **15 · 14 · 10**
At the open, at least 4 (06:20, Sun 07:15)	4 · 4 · 3	✓ **4 · 4 · 4**
Still on duty at 22:00, at least 5	4 · 2 · 3	✓ **7 · 6 · 5**
Through to the close, at least 3	2 · 2 · 3	✓ **3 · 3 · 3**
Fewest on the floor at any time, at least 2	2 · 2 · 2	✓ **3 · 3 · 3**

Every level met on every day — and the ticket office staffed in pairs, including Sundays.

People where the trains are

Fit to the trains: floor staff against the December trains, hour by hour — lower is better



Staffing follows the December trains more closely every day — far more at weekends.

People and hours

What it takes to run

	Today	Middle Ground
People on the link	20	**26**
Contracted hours a week	35h	**35h**
Cover weeks (for leave and sickness)	4 of 20 (20%)	**5 of 26 (19%)**
People needed each Sunday (overtime)	8	**10**

Six more people, the same 35-hour week — and Sundays are still worked as overtime.

Fatigue checks

Office of Rail and Road and rail-industry good practice — not a fatigue risk assessment

	Today	Middle Ground
Avoidable fatigue warnings, cover weeks aside	4 (up to 5)	✓ 0 (up to 1)
Most days in a row (limit 13)	7 (up to 9)	✓ 5 (up to 7)
Shortest rest between shifts (limit 12h)	12h 30m	✓ 14h 35m
Longest shift, any day	9h 10m	✓ 8h 30m

Rest and days-in-a-row limits met with room to spare. In brackets: the worst case, if a cover week falls badly.

Why Middle Ground?

What all three shortlisted links give, what this one adds, and what it costs

- ✓ All three: all 9 December rules; no avoidable fatigue warning, cover weeks aside
- ✓ All three: no two closing weeks in a row, cover weeks aside
- ✓ All three: today’s leave — 30 days off for 14 days’ leave, four weeks off for 14
- ✓ All three: no shift over 9 hours, and every closing shift shorter
- ✓ This one adds: nothing over 8h 30m on any day, and the closest Saturday fit
- ▲ This one costs: the fewest finishes before 14:00, and four at the open every day

What all three cost: more late finishes and two more Saturdays a year.

What colleagues will notice

The three biggest gains and costs, per person, cover weeks aside

Likely to welcome

- **More weekends off**
  14 full weekends a year, not 10
- **Fewer days in a row**
  5 at most, not 7
- **Nothing over 8h 30m, any day**
  today’s longest is 9h 10m

Likely to worry about

- **More late finishes**
  94 a year at 22:00 or later, not 78
- **More single rest days**
  about 12 a year, not 10
- **Less premium and overtime pay**
  about £350 a year, gross,
  for a full share of Sundays, swaps aside

Expect late finishes and single rest days first — the colleague presentation answers both.

Where it stands

Three things settled, two decisions left, two points still open

- ✓ **December rules — confirmed verbally**
  Everything here is built on them; worth having in writing before a link is chosen.
- ✓ **26 people on the link — decided**
  Six more than today, with five cover weeks.
- ✓ **Sunday cover — confirmed verbally**
  Ten on a Sunday — Sunday work stays overtime.
- ? **To decide: which link we use**
  After colleagues' views. Not yet through the roster office.
- ? **Then: who starts on which line**
  Decided after the link is chosen.

Still open: where the 13-day limit is written; how one fatigue check treats a rest day.



The detail

- Every week of the link, day by day
- Staff on duty hour by hour, against the trains
- Every December rule and fatigue check, worked through

All in the eight-page proposal sheet · Middle Ground · MG-26-T8 · 20668ac9